

**The Role of Media in Exacerbating Gender Inequality in Pakistan: A Thematic
Discourse Analysis of TV Drama, ‘Raqs-e-bismil’**

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

CDA: Critical Discourse Analysis

DA: Discourse Analysis

OECD: Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development

SIGI: Social Institutions and Gender Index

STEM: Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics

ILOSTAT: International Labour Organization Statistics

TDA: Thematic Discourse Analysis

TRP: Television Rating Point

UN: United Nations

UNDP: United Nations Development Programme

UNICEF: United Nations International Children's Emergency Fund

ABSTRACT

Pakistan, despite decades of efforts, continues to see astronomical levels of gender inequality. The fundamental cause of these inequalities is the social exclusion of women, which is exacerbated by the informal institutions of patriarchy, regressive gender norms and gender roles. It has been found that an outlet that can regulate these institutions is the media. This paper investigates the crucial role gender representations in primetime television dramas play in shaping gender-related social realities in Pakistan. This is achieved by conducting a Thematic Discourse Analysis (TDA) on the popular TV drama 'Raqs-e-bismil', and discourse analysis (DA) on the audience's reaction to gender representations in this drama. The TDA found the themes of patriarchy, lack of autonomy of women, objectification of women, stereotypical gender traits, gender roles and lack of individuality of women to be present in the drama. This, along with the DA and the literature review, indicates that media plays a role in shaping the social institutions of Pakistan and consequently impacts gender inequality in the country.

Keywords: Gender-inequality, informal institutions, social norms, media, social exclusion.

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DECLARATION

I declare that this submission is my own work. No portion of the work referred to in the dissertation has been submitted in support of an application for another degree or qualification of this or any other university or other institute of learning. Any ideas or information that is not mine is cited and present in the bibliography.

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CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 BACKGROUND

Women make up half of the world's population, 49.6% to be exact (World Bank, 2020), yet they continue to battle discrimination, deprivation, and oppression throughout their lives. They face all sorts of injustices such as discriminatory wage gaps, minimal political representation, lack of autonomy, sexual abuse and violence, time poverty, unequal access to health, and low educational attainment, to name a few. Of course, the extent of discrimination faced by them is subject to the intersectionality of inequality, that is, some ethnicities, nationalities, and social classes of women suffer relatively more than others. Regardless, gender inequality is a global phenomenon, one that has been a growing concern and a topic of interest for researchers. The author of this article studies this phenomenon using a single-country case study.

Pakistan is the selected case study for this paper due to the country's persistent poor performance on inequality indicators and indexes. According to the Global Gender Gap Index of 2021, Pakistan ranks 145/146, 2nd worst in the world in terms of gender equality (World Economic Forum, 2022). The Gender Inequality Index measures gender inequality in three dimensions: reproductive health, empowerment, and labour markets; Pakistan scored 0.766 out of 0.9 (UNDP, 2019a). A high score on this index indicates high levels of inequality in the country. The Gender Development Index, which is a gendered version of HDI, scores Pakistan as 0.615, 2nd worst in South Asia and 4th worst worldwide (UNDP, 2019b). The Social Institutions and Gender Index (SIGI) is a comprehensive measure of how discriminatory the social institutions of a country are. SIGI 2019 places Pakistan in the very high category, with

discrimination in the family at 79.8%, restricted access to productive and financial resources at 60%, and restricted civil liberties at 53.1% (OECD, 2019).

The statistics presented above are an indication of the profound levels of gender inequality that exist in Pakistan. It is evident that gender inequalities exist, but why women suffer such blatant discrimination and why this has not improved over time is more complex to understand. While the literature provides many explanations, this paper uses Social Exclusion Theory and Poststructuralist Feminism to explore the answers to these questions. Social exclusion, through informal social institutions, regulates and exacerbates gender inequality and therefore can explain why gender inequality continues to exist in society. Additionally, poststructuralist feminism identifies media as a form of discourse that can construct social realities and identities. Therefore, the paper addresses the role media can play in shaping the informal social institutions that cause the social exclusion of women. These theories not only explain the phenomenon but also provide justifications for possible interventions. These ideas are extensively explored in Chapter 2 and justify why the author chooses to evaluate the medium of broadcast media.

1.2 SHAPE AND SCOPE OF THE STUDY

This study aims to investigate the extent to which primetime TV dramas (the most popular form of broadcast media in the country) reinforce regressive gender ideals in Pakistan. The methodology used for this evaluation is Thematic Discourse Analysis (TDA), conducted on the drama ‘Raqs-e-bismil’. This paper aims to contribute to the currently limited body of literature in Pakistan. The current media literature in Pakistan analyzes advertisements, or those that analyze TV dramas use a different methodology than that used in this paper or analyze limited characters or episodes instead of the entire drama. The author attempts to address some

of the limitations of other research. Moreover, the author of this paper expands knowledge on this topic by bringing insights into how people react to the content instead of just analyzing media content. This is achieved by using review channels as a proxy for the audiences' reaction. Pakistan has a culture of review channels on Instagram and Youtube that critique TV dramas and movies, they address production quality, storylines and acting. Analyzing how these review channels react to the regressive ideals portrayed on television can provide insight into the perception of the audience.

Like any academic material, this paper does come with its limitations, largely due to a lack of resources. Although analyzing just one television drama might not be enough for any quantitative assertions regarding the overall state of Pakistan's television dramas, the depth that the author wants to achieve by thoroughly reviewing one television drama will be a useful addition to the limited existing literature. Moreover, the reviews analyzed cannot be fully representative of the population; they are, however, sufficient as a preliminary analysis of the audience. The combination of the TV drama and reviews could provide key insights into the phenomenon of gender equality in the country and the mechanisms that can be used to reduce it. The methods used in this paper will achieve depth and create the potential for larger-scale future research that can be used to justify policies.

The paper is organized as follows. Chapter 2 addresses the literature review that further investigates the phenomenon of gender inequality globally and in Pakistan. The chapter goes on to elaborate on the ideas introduced in Chapter 1, such as poststructuralist feminism and social exclusion. Finally, the chapter discusses the significance of media in the gender inequality debate and justifies the author's research approach. This is followed by Chapter 3, which is the methodology section of this paper. The chapter provides an overview of the

research aim, the research questions, the methods, the data, and the limitations. Chapter 4 considers the results and analysis. It will outline and explain the themes that were derived through the TDA, and the results of the analysis conducted on the review channels. The analysis section of the chapter explores linkages between the themes derived and the literature review. Finally, chapter 5 provides the conclusion of the study. Beyond summarizing the paper, the chapter will explain the potential for future research and outline policy recommendations.

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 INTRODUCTION

Gender is a vast area of research, and gender-based inequalities a global phenomenon. Recent decades have witnessed a growing interest in gender and media studies. This research adds to that discussion by examining the relationship between gender inequality, social institutions, and media. The following review of the literature will attempt to justify this article by exploring this relationship in the case of Pakistan. The chapter begins by addressing the plethora of gender inequalities that are faced by women globally. The literature presented in the section finds that women throughout the world face health, finance, employment, education, and wealth-related disparities. The following section offers a comprehensive overview of gender inequality in Pakistan and the role that institutions play in facilitating it. The rigid informal institutions in the country that devalue femininity cause the social exclusion of Pakistani women, which consequently deprives them of rights and resources. The final section will elaborate on the relationship between media and gender and set the premise for why media is explored in this dissertation. It examines post-structuralist feminist ideas that address the significant role of media in increasing gender inequality. The section will also outline existing media research in Pakistan and the gap that this paper addresses.

2.2 GLOBAL GENDER INEQUALITY

UNICEF defines gender equality as

Women and men [facing] equal conditions, treatment, and opportunities for realizing their full potential, human rights, and dignity, and for contributing to (and benefitting from) economic, social, cultural and political development (Unicef, 2017).

Unfortunately, due to discrimination that arises from regressive gender norms and social constructs, this equality is far from being realized. While recent decades have brought about some positive developments, gender inequality remains a substantial and detrimental problem everywhere (World Bank, 2022). This section addresses a plethora of challenges facing women worldwide in health, education, labour and gender-based violence.

2.2.1 Health Disparities

Amartya Sen's concept of 'missing women' is the most concise yet elaborate explanation of the health disparities that exist in the world, especially in the global south. He found that due to the discrimination women face that affects their health, there are millions of women missing from the population of developing countries, especially in South Asia (Sen, 1992; 2003). Sen argues that current gender-based health disparities astronomically decrease a woman's chance of survival; in contrast, if women received the same treatment as men, their population size would be much larger today with higher survival rates and lower mortality. In South Asia¹, women face many different forms of discrimination (throughout their lives) that harm their health, such as lack of access to health care, malnutrition, male child preference, lack of mobility, lack of state support, lack of reproductive rights, gender-based violence and gender disproportionate distribution of resources (Ahmed et al., 2000; Fikree and Pasha, 2004; Nasrullah and Bhatti, 2012; Namasivayam et al., 2012; Rizvi, Khan and Shaikh, 2014). Similarly, in Africa, women are more vulnerable to HIV, maternal mortality, and gender-based violence due to the discrimination they face in accessing adequate healthcare (MacPherson et al., 2014; Magadi, 2011).

¹ On many occasions in this section the author generalizes findings to an entire region. While there might be differences between countries within a region, the research cited address most countries within the mentioned region and find similar results across the countries.

Additionally, while some global progress has been made in the rate of maternal mortality, adolescent pregnancy is still prevalent in many countries and the mortality resulting from it is high (World Bank, 2022; World Health Organization, 2015). In Africa and Asia, factors associated with adolescent pregnancy are poverty, early marriage, lack of education, lack of awareness of reproductive health, inadequate access to healthcare, and gender-based violence (Gubhaju, 2002; Kassa et al., 2018; Papri et al., 2016; Raj et al., 2010; Yakubu and Salisu, 2018; Worku et al., 2021).

A common factor that affects women's health in all regions is gender-based violence (Decker et al., 2013; Decker et al., 2015). Global evidence suggests that more than one in three women face gender-based violence at least once in their lifetime (World Bank, 2022). A meta-analysis conducted by Muluneh et al. (2020) on gender-based violence in sub-Saharan Africa found varying but consistently high levels prevalent throughout the continent. Moreover, African women who face gender-based violence are at increased risk of HIV infection (Dunkle et al., 2004). In Latin America and the Caribbean, the lifetime prevalence of intimate partner violence ranges from between 20 and 50% of women (Morrison, Ellsberg, and Bott, 2004). In Asia and the Pacific, the proportion of women experiencing gender-based violence ranges from 15% to 68% (UN Women, 2019). The violence faced by these women deteriorates their overall physical health, mental health, and quality of life (Heise, Ellsberg and Gottmoeller, 2002; Krug et al., 2002; Lucena, et al., 2017; Rees, et al., 2011; Rees, et al., 2014; Sanjel, 2013; Vázquez, Torres and Otero, 2012; Veronese, Mahmid and Bdier, 2022).

2.2.2 Economic Opportunities and Resources

Unfortunately, the health inequalities women face are just a drop in the ocean; the challenges they face span many areas of their lives, education also being part of the long list.

The gender gap in education and female learning poverty remains high, especially in the global south, due to gender bias, early marriages, and poverty (World Bank, 2022). Llie and Rose (2016) studied whether South Asia and sub-Saharan Africa can achieve the goal of equal access to education by 2030. They found the disparities in education to be so great that the educational attainment rate required to achieve equal access to education would at least have to triple. The current climate in the regions makes this difficult to achieve and would require extreme interventions. Moreover, they found that despite a slightly narrowing gap in primary and secondary education, gaps in higher education have increased. They found that rich young men were more likely to be enrolled in education and poor young women least likely. The intersectionality that comes with gender issues is evident here, with lower-class women at a relatively higher disadvantage, struggling to achieve high educational attainment. These disadvantages faced by women in education translate into the labour market.

The gap in education negatively impacts labour force participation, wages, and occupational segregation, keeping many women and girls away from STEM fields (Kanwal and Munir, 2015; Klasen and Lamanna, 2008; World Bank, 2022). In Latin America and Asia women in the labour force are usually found in low-paying jobs with a lack of job security (Cameron, Dowling and Worswick, 2001; Hoffman and Centeno, 2003; Rahman and Islam, 2013; Tanaka and Muzones, 2016; Unterhalter, 2006; Verick, 2014). The shortage of Latin American women in higher education has a huge impact on the economic opportunities they face. In Africa, Asia, and Latin America, the domestic and reproductive role of women is also a significant barrier to their labour force participation (Hoffman and Centeno, 2003; Kabeer, Deshpande and Assaad, 2019; Kes and Swaminathan, 2006; Klasen, 2019). The huge burden of unpaid care responsibilities they endure keeps them away from the market. Furthermore, both Latin American and Asian Female-headed households are at a greater risk of poverty than male-

headed households (Buvinić and Gupta, 1997; Hoffman and Centeno, 2003; Gangopadhyay and Wadhwa, 2004; Klasen, Lechtenfeld and Povel, 2015; Majeed and Malik, 2015). Despite women of the global north facing relatively better job opportunities than those in the global south, Australian, Canadian, and European women also suffer the consequences of patriarchy through bias in childcare responsibilities, discrimination in the workforce and wage gaps (Amate-Fortes et al., 2021; Babacan, 2004; Mencarini and Sironi, 2012; Johnston, Mohammed and Linden 2020).

In addition to gender disparity in the labour market, women also face a financial disadvantage in wealth and property. Latin American Women suffer a huge gender bias in the land, labour, and credit market, which prevents them from land ownership (Deere and Leon, 2003; Hoffman and Centeno, 2003). Deere and Leon (2003) found that Latin American women also face discrimination in inheritance and state-led land distribution programs. The few women that do own land, own much smaller and lower-quality land compared to men. Similar disparities have been found in Africa (Cherryl, 2009; Doss et al., 2015; O'Sullivan, 2017) and South Asia (Ahmed, Batool, and Dziegielewski, 2016; Chowdhry, 2009; Shambhavi, 2022). Interventions that enhance women's property rights and bridge the land ownership gap have time and again been found to significantly increase a woman's economic opportunities and bargaining power within the household (Agarwal, 1997; Amjad, 2018; Brixiová, Kangoye and Tregenna, 2020; Hossain and Nikolov, 2021; Kelkar, 2014; Mishra and Sam, 2016).

2.3 GENDER INEQUALITY IN PAKISTAN

This previous section of the literature review has managed to authenticate the author's very first statement: 'Gender-based inequalities [are] a global phenomenon'. While most of the research previously presented includes Pakistan, the focus of this paper necessitates a more in-

depth evaluation. This section will go beyond just the existence of the phenomenon, rather, it will delve into the why and how of it all.

As previously mentioned in Chapter 1, Pakistan is one of the countries with the lowest scores on gender-related indicators and metrics. Furthermore, a brief overview of gender-related statistics confirms just how deep gender inequality in Pakistan runs. 24.5% of women experience intimate partner violence at least once in their lifetime (NIPS, 2019). 18.3% of women aged 20-24 years were married before turning 18 (UNICEF, 2021). In 2021, the gender wage gap for professionals, technicians, and skilled agricultural workers was 18.4%, 12%, and 44.6%, respectively (ILOSTAT, 2021a). In 2021, the labour force participation rate of the working-age population is 78.5% for men and 21% for women (ILOSTAT, 2021b). The statistics mentioned here are a clear indicator of the astronomically high levels of gender inequality that exist in the country.

While the existence of gender inequality cannot be challenged, the answer as to why it exists is a bit more complex. One dimension of this is the devaluation of women that is cultivated by social institutions. A simple example of this is the phrase ‘Sinf-e-Nazuq’, an Urdu phrase used to describe women in Pakistan. The precise translation of this phrase is ‘the weaker species’. Over time, the use of this phrase to address women has become so common that websites translate the phrase to ‘women kind’ instead of ‘the weaker species’. This phrase is a simplified, yet profound example of how women are treated as inferior to men. Several studies have found that the negative connotations associated with femininity negate the way women are treated socially and politically (Eckert and McConnell-Ginet, 1992; 2013; Romaine, 1998).

2.3.1 Institutions and the politics of gender

Informal institutions play an important role in determining how women are treated. In this study, institutions are defined as the “rules of the game” (North, 1990). Formal institutions can be defined as political, legal, and economic systems that regulate individual and collective behaviour, whereas informal institutions are norms that shape how formal institutions operate, for example, political ideology, corruption, and culture (Helmke and Levitsky, 2004). If political actors shaping policies and passing laws are influenced by gender-biased social institutions, then the policies and laws they create are also likely to be gender-blind. The impact this gender blindness can have has been further explored in Chapter 5. The rest of this section will elaborate on such socio-cultural institutions that mediate gender inequality in Pakistan and address the consequences of it through social exclusion.

The social institution at the core of this issue is patriarchy, a male-favouring system that has been sustained for centuries (Moghadam, 1992; Wassan, Channa and Shah, 2021). Other gender-biased socio-cultural institutions such as regressive norms or gender roles emerge from the ideology created by patriarchy (Habiba and Ashfaq, 2016; Mason and Smith, 2003). There are three core ways in which all these institutions have created adversity for women. First, rigid gender roles have emerged, with women confined to reproductive roles as unpaid caregivers and nurturers, and men to productive roles as heads of the household/breadwinners (Ahmed et al., 2019; Aziz and Kamal, 2012; Hussain, 2015). The social norms that emerge from this make it extremely difficult for women to survive in the labour market (Ali et al., 2012; Mahmood et al., 2012; Raza and Murad, 2010). Women are not only discouraged from entering the labour force but a married woman who manages to enter struggles to retain herself in a productive role once she has children. Gender disparities in time poverty can also be attributed to this; the huge burden of reproductive and caregiving duties that women carry impedes their

participation and productivity in the labour force (Iqbal et al., 2020; Rehman and Roomi, 2012; Saqib and Arif, 2012; Zilanawala, 2014). A woman, employed or unemployed, is always expected to carry out her domestic, reproductive, and unpaid care responsibilities without the help or burden sharing of men.

Furthermore, parents prefer to invest in their son's education rather than their daughter's, as the belief that it is only their son who can play a productive role and earn them money makes the investment in their daughter's education futile (Ellahi et al., 2010; Jehan, Khan and Sadiqa, 2021; Khan, Azhar and Shah, 2011; Maqsood, Maqsood and Raza, 2012; Moheyuddin, 2005; Purewal and Hashmi, 2014). The lack of educational attainment of women, which is a consequence of these social institutions, directly impacts a woman's ability to get a well-paying and secure job.

Second, in addition to defining their competence and abilities, gender roles also force conformity to gender-specific personality types and behaviour. Men are characterized as decision-makers, assertive, competent, and independent; whereas women are characterized as nurturing, submissive, passive, and dependent (Ahmed et al., 2019; Bilwani and Anjum, 2021; Pervaiz, 1980). Women or men who in any way diverge from these characteristics are condemned and disparaged by society. These personality traits also reinforce the reproductive/productive role that has been assigned to gender, making it ever more difficult to break out of the norms. The stereotypes that emerge from this that devalue femininity are another factor that makes it extremely difficult for a woman to do anything that diverges from her socially assigned gender role. It conditions men to think that women are incompetent outside of their designated reproductive role, preventing their recruitment into secure well-

paying productive jobs (Diwan and Vartanova, 2017; Kabeer, Deshpande and Assaad, 2019; Masitoh and Pramesti, 2020).

Third, the assertive trait of men, the submissive trait of women and the imbalance of power brought by the institution give the patriarch of the family decision-making power over everyone in the household. This has robbed women of their autonomy, especially over personal decisions such as education, career, or marriage (Ali et al., 2010; Bushra and Wajiha, 2015; Chaudhry and Nosheen, 2009). The type of job a woman can do, where she can travel/commute to, who she marries, when she gets married, where she can study, the level of education she can receive, all of these might sound like personal decisions, but for Pakistani woman, these are to a great extent out of her control.

2.3.2 Social Exclusion

Ultimately, the consequence of all these gender-biased social institutions that devalue women and femininity is social exclusion (Kabeer, 2000). The significance of this theory for this paper is the bridge it creates between social institutions and gender inequalities. It provides a more focused and coherent explanation for why social institutions can fortify gender inequality. The assumption here is that gender inequalities emerge from the social exclusion of women. This paper uses Levitas et al. (2007)'s definition of social exclusion:

Involves the lack or denial of resources, rights, goods and services, and the inability to participate in the normal relationships and activities, available to the majority of people in a society, whether in economic, social, cultural or political arenas. (Pg. 9).

Naila Kabeer's Social Exclusion theory is a prominent concept used to understand how certain groups experience disadvantages through the dynamics of social interaction. Social exclusion can be further explained using the terms problematic groups (those that are at a relative

disadvantage), problematic conditions (the consequences problematic groups face due to the exclusion for example poverty) and problematic processes (which can be either political, social, or economic) (Kabeer, 2000). Although this theory encompasses many types of problematic groups, the problematic group that this article will address is women. Additionally, the dynamics of social interactions and informal social institutions, which can devalue women and discriminate against them can be described as a problematic process.

Social exclusion theory can be used to evaluate the deprivation of resources and/or rights that Pakistani women face through social institutions. Gender asymmetry in resource allocation, which is persistent from a woman's childhood, is a problematic process emerging from social institutions. Since men are expected to be productive economic actors, less money is invested in the education of girls, further decreasing their value in the labour market (Chaudhry and Nosheen, 2009; Jehan, Khan, and Sadiqa, 2021; Khan, Azhar and Shah, 2011; Purewal and Hashmi, 2014; Salik and Zhiyong, 2014). Young girls are also deprived of resources such as food due to the preferential treatment of male children. Social norms that deprive women of their right to make decisions and restrict their mobility also contribute to women's inability to receive education (Ahmad et al., 2014; Ghazi et al., 2011; Jehan, Khan and Sadiqa, 2021; Pirzado, 2006; Purewal and Hashmi, 2014). Women, especially those living in rural areas, cannot travel without their husband's or father's permission. Due to religious reasons, some women are even discouraged from travelling alone. This reduces girls' and women's access to schools and universities. Moreover, some norms even discourage the high educational attainment of women due to their domestic role, since these women do not have the freedom to make their own decisions in this regard, they are forced to stay out of education. The social institutions that uphold these social norms can be described as one of the problematic processes that cause the social exclusion of women.

Additionally, the gender-specific distribution of responsibilities also acts as a form of deprivation of rights or problematic conditions (Kabeer, 1997). Women are found to be four times more time-poor than men (Time Use Survey, 2007). Regardless of whether a woman is employed or unemployed, the burden of unpaid domestic/care work falls in her hands alone (Iqbal et al., 2020; Zilanawala, 2014). This not only prevents women's participation as economic agents in the labour market but also confines women to the informal sector with low wage rates and high job insecurity (Masitoh and Pramesti, 2020; Rehman and Roomi, 2012; Saqib and Arif, 2012).

In an economy like Pakistan with high levels of poverty, it is important to address the intersectionality of social exclusion, that is, while women are a problematic group, other problematic groups such as poor, lower class, disabled, and caste can also contain women, increasing the problematic conditions of those belonging to multiple groups. This means that the magnitude of social exclusion endured by women also differs by class. For example, women living in rural areas have a higher work burden with the expectation of performing unpaid agricultural work and additional domestic responsibilities due to the need to collect fodder, firewood and water (Saqib and Arif, 2012; Jan and Pervez, 2015). Lower-class women also face far more barriers to education than higher-class women due to more rigorous rules, weak infrastructure, lack of finances, lower education of parents, and early marriages (Hussain, Zulfiqar and Ullah, 2020; Shah and Shah, 2012).

2.4 THE SIGNIFICANCE OF MEDIA AND GENDER

The extensive body of literature presented above proves the significant influence socio-cultural institutions have on gender inequality and exclusion. As a matter of course, policies

used to increase gender equality and empower women need to run much deeper than just economic interventions; instead, policies need to shift focus towards mobilizing mechanisms that can promote gender inclusion in social institutions (Branisa, Klasen and Ziegler, 2013; Qureshi and Shaikh, 2007). That is not to say that other interventions are not equally essential. Since informal institutions shape how formal institutions work; economic/political interventions along with social-institution-shaping interventions could make a more meaningful impact on decreasing gender-related inequalities. For example, building a school in a village to increase access to education could be ineffective if parents prevent their daughter's education due to cultural motivations. However, if the sociocultural concepts of early marriages or male preference are addressed, then a school in the village would be more effective in incentivizing parents to educate their daughters.

Academia provides many solutions to social-institution-related problems, the one proposed by the author of this paper is based on post-structuralist feminism. Poststructuralist feminism postulates that gender inequalities can be attributed to social constructs of gender identity. This has already been largely evidenced in the first half of this chapter. The ideology that emerges from this school creates a link between social institutions, power, and discourse. The underlying idea is that gender-biased discourse can reinforce patriarchal power structures and devalue femininity (Davies and Gannon, 2005; Soza, 2014). This discourse can be written, verbal or visual.

Gender-biased discourse used in any context (advertisements, television, news, books etc.) can shape values and consequently, influence the social and political treatment of genders (Eckert and McConnell-Ginet, 1992; 2013; Romaine, 1998). Poststructuralist scholars argue that media (as a type of discourse) plays a significant role in constructing social realities and gender

identity (Mendes and Carter, 2008). The portrayal of weak and submissive women and strong and dominant men has helped to construct what can be categorized as masculine or feminine. This categorization translates into the reinforcement of rigid gender norms, rules, and roles, that is, informal social institutions. Moreover, the kind of content that a writer, director, or producer creates can be heavily influenced by their own personal biases and value systems. A content creator who believes in the inferiority of women is likely to create content using that bias. Therefore, due to the lack of female directors, writers, producers, and distributors, the female perspective and voice are lost, allowing for further misrepresentation of women and the portrayal of patriarchal ideas (Isanovi, 2006; Steiner, 2014).

The post-structuralist ideas outlined above are what shape the methodology of this paper. The underlying idea is that what is portrayed in the media can represent the value system of society, while also acting as a reinforcer of these values. If regressive ideals, such as the inferiority of women, are portrayed in the media in a positive light, these ideals continue to be accepted and replicated by society. Therefore, changing how gender is represented in broadcast media can be one of the mechanisms that can create a shift in how gender is treated in Pakistan; the policy implications of which are further discussed in Chapter 5. It is worthy of note here that the main aim of this paper is not to provide concrete policies, but rather to establish the extent to which gender representations in broadcast media coincide with the informal social institutions of Pakistan explored in this chapter. However, this is only one part of the analysis conducted in this paper. The second part of this analysis, which studies the review channels, provides another layer of information on how the audience perceives the portrayal of gender on television. How the audience reacts to the biased portrayal of women on television can reaffirm the ideas presented so far. It allows for a more concrete evaluation of the extent to which media portrayal impacts societal values. The analysis of the review channels makes this paper stand

out among the current literature. Both parts of this analysis combined, if compatible with what post-structuralism suggests, can add to the small body of current literature and provide an incentive for larger-scale research that would be able to back up future interventions.

2.4.1 Media Research in Pakistan

The current body of research in Pakistan coincides with the post-structuralist ideas presented in this chapter. Television dramas in Pakistan are ideologically driven and reproduce “hegemonic masculinity and (subordinate) femininity” (Khan, Ullah and Ahmad, 2018, p. 74). Studies on Pakistan TV adverts and TV Dramas find that they objectify women and create unrealistic body standards; a sexualization that limits the value of a woman to her looks rather than her personality or intellect (Waheed, Qamar and Malik, 2018; Rasool, Ali and Khan, 2022; Rubab et al., 2021; Ullah, 2014). Furthermore, female characters that do not conform to stereotypical gender roles are portrayed as negative, whereas positive ones tend to have passive, naïve, and subservient traits (Ashfaq and Shafiq, 2018; Iqbal and Abdar, 2016; Khan, Khurshid and Kayany, 2016; Qamar and Farukh, 2021). Women who go against social norms and patriarchal ideology are usually condemned using 'honour', are labelled with the responsibility of carrying the honour of their family on their shoulders and are called immoral and dishonourable, a discourse that is prominent in the television portrayal of women as well (Fatima, 2019; Kothari, 2005).

Moreover, there is a portrayal of rigid gender roles and a normalization of domestic violence on television, with violent male characters not facing repercussions for their actions and female characters seen as enduring and accepting violence (Cheema, 2016; Khan, 2021; Mehra, 2019; Ullah and Nisar, 2011). The constant depiction of women in such a negative and objectifying light can influence the ideology of the audience and condition people into reinforcing the

regressive ideals and sociocultural norms portrayed in media as proposed by poststructuralist scholars (Iqbal and Abdar, 2016).

2.4.2 Research Gap

Pakistan's existing media literature provides many useful insights; however, the low volume of research means that the current body has many gaps, some of which are successfully addressed by this paper. Firstly, the drama *Raqs –e-bismil* has not been analysed before, and the other dramas that have been studied use thematic analysis (TA) or critical discourse analysis (CDA) as the method (Ahmed & Wahab, 2019; Chaudhry, Ali and Aslam, 2021; Khan, 2021; Khan, Ullah and Ahmad, 2018; Khan, Khurshid and Kayany, 2016; Manzoor, Jabeen and Hanif, 2018). This study uses TDA, which is an integration of TA and CDA, allowing for a more comprehensive and insightful analysis. The justification for using *Raqs-e-bismil* for the analysis is also further elaborated in Chapter 3.

Secondly, the existing literature on broadcast media in Pakistan uses TV advertisements (Ali et al., 2012; Ali, 2018; Iftikhar, Aziz and Latif, 2011), is extremely dated (Kothari, 1997; Suleman, 1990), only reviews certain scenes in the tv drama instead of the drama as a whole (Qamar and Farrukh, 2021; Rasool, Ali and Khan, 2022; Tahir, Shah and Yasir, 2021) or does not address the issue of gender (Fatima, 2019; Ijaz, Shah and Mahmood, 2022; Afzal, Shah and Hayat, 2021; Tahir, Shah and Yasir, 2021). Each study has its limitations on the method or data used; the author seeks to eliminate these limitations to address current gaps in the literature.

Finally, this study also addresses the audience, which has not been explored by previous research. The few studies that address the audience do not address the issue of gender in Pakistan (Karim & Shehzad, 2016; Mehra, 2019; Zia, 2014). When trying to understand the

overall role of media in regulating social institutions and gender inequality, how the audience is reacting to the drama can provide powerful insights into the politics of gender. It allows a better understanding of the magnitude of the media's impact media.

2.5 CONCLUSION

In summary, gender inequality in Pakistan has been exacerbated by women's social exclusion through social institutions. The devaluation of women and femininity encouraged by these social institutions seems to be at the centre of the debate. This devaluation, which determines society's value system, reduces the economic, political, and social status of women. The consequence of this is a vicious cycle, with inferiority limiting the ability of women to become productive members of society, and their inability to become productive members of society further devaluing them. The purpose of this chapter was to highlight the role media can play in placating gender inequalities. Media, according to post-structural scholars, shapes social reality and constructs gender identity; therefore, it can regulate social institutions. This justifies the authors' use of television dramas as the subject of interest. Ultimately, the link between media, institutions, and gender inequality, provides a solid foundation for the purpose and methods of the paper.

CHAPTER 3: METHODOLOGY

3.1 INTRODUCTION

This chapter will outline the research questions, design, and methods that align with the purpose of this research. The research design section elaborates on why Pakistan is chosen as a case study and provides an overview of the data used. The methods section outlines the chosen method of analysis and how this paper addresses a gap in the existing literature. Finally, the chapter outlines some of the limitations of this paper, along with justifications for it.

3.1.1 Research Aim

The overall aim of this study is to explore how gender is portrayed in broadcast media and how this portrayal is perceived by the population. Given that media has a significant influence over behaviour and ideology (Hjarvard, 2008), an in-depth analysis of popular forms of media in a country can provide insight into the sociocultural institutions of a country. With this paper, the author aims to understand how gender and gender identity are treated in media and the extent to which this aligns with sociocultural norms. Ultimately, the author hopes to gain a deeper understanding of the mechanisms through which media portrayal of gender might impact gender inequality in the country through socio-cultural institutions.

3.2 RESEARCH QUESTIONS

This study will explore three research questions:

1. How are men and women presented in popular Pakistani Dramas?
2. To what extent does the identity of men and women presented in Pakistani television coincide with the sociocultural institutions of the country?
3. How do popular review channels react to how gender is presented in TV dramas?

The first question focuses on how the social identity of men and women is presented in broadcast media, more specifically, popular TV dramas. The purpose here is to explore the similarities and differences in how the gender identity of men and women is formed. There are two things of importance when looking into the identity of gender: Toxic masculinity and inferior femininity. Given the lack of resources available to the author, this paper will explore just one TV drama that received the highest Television Rating Point (TRP) in the year 2021. Regardless, the insights from this paper will be an important addition to the currently limited available literature. The paper will also aim to provide a framework for future large-scale research.

The second question is more nuanced in its exploration. It is a deeper understanding of the sociocultural institutions within a country and the extent to which these are present in TV dramas. Feminist media theories postulate that the relationship between media representation and social norms is bidirectional, which means, social norms can inform representation in media and media can reinforce regressive sociocultural norms (Hjarvard, 2008; Kothari, 2005; Shabir, Safdar and Imran, 2013; Steiner, 2014; Williams et al., 2016; Wood, 1994). The preliminary exploration of Question 2 is done in section 2.3.1 of Chapter 2. Section 4.4 of Chapter four will provide a bridge between the findings from chapter two and the results outlined in section 4.2 to answer this question.

The final question aims to understand how the audience reacts to regressive ideas and themes presented in TV Dramas. Is the audience accepting of the themes, or is dissent towards the regressive ideals present? The limited resources available to the author do not allow for conducting interviews/questionnaires with the audience. Therefore, reviews of the selected

drama posted by 4 of the most popular review channels are used as a proxy. In Pakistan, review channels tend to post detailed episode-by-episode opinions on the drama. These reviews have gained popularity and have a large audience. While this is in no way meant to be fully representative of the audience or its opinion, it can provide preliminary insights into how people react to TV dramas and provide a foundation for future larger-scale research. If there is common disapproval of the gender norms portrayed on television, this could create potential for new research into why gender-based social norms continue to exist. If the reverse is found and the gender norms are celebrated, this can be used to justify policies governing social institutions as interventions to combat gender inequality.

3.3 RESEARCH DESIGN

3.3.1 Case Study

As discussed in chapter 1, Pakistan is chosen as a case study for this paper because of the extent of the inequality that persists in the country. In this case, gender inequality is highly linked to sociocultural institutions (Hakim and Aziz, 1998; Hamid and Ahmed, 2011; Razi et al., 2020). Of the factors that influence sociocultural institutions, media is a significant yet under-researched facet. The dire need to address gender issues in the country and the scarcity of media/gender research in the country makes Pakistan the perfect case study for this paper. Despite the focus on one country, this paper still adds to the pool of media and development research as an insight into the influence of media.

3.3.2 Data

The methodology of this paper has been designed considering the nature of the complex nature of the phenomenon under review. The issue of identity, gender, and inequality is one that needs a qualitative analysis rather than a quantitative one. To address the first and second

research questions, the author of this study will conduct a TDA of the TV drama 'Raqs-e-bismil'. The drama airs on HUM TV, the most popular TV channel in Pakistan. HUM TV has a large audience, and the drama aired during prime time, which has the highest male and female viewership. There are two reasons the paper opts for this particular TV drama. First, there are no current studies that analyse this drama, so it makes a useful and unique addition to the existing literature. Second, it was one of the most popular TV dramas that aired in 2021. With a total of 28 episodes, it has one of the highest TRPs in 2021. The TRP of the episodes ranged from 6.2 to 9.4. For reference, a good TRP is a steady 3.0 (Dhawan, 2020). Additionally, on YouTube, where it was trending in the top 5 in Pakistan every week, the drama received 15-20 million views per episode. Since the scope of the study does not allow reviewing more than one television drama, the drama chosen needed to be one that was popular. This ensures that the results are a meaningful addition to the current literature.

To address the third research question, discourse analysis will be undertaken on the reviews written by 4 of the most popular review channels in Pakistan: Fuchsia magazine, Something Haute, Afia blogs, and Galaxy Lollywood. The analysis will be conducted using the themes derived in the first stage to evaluate how these blogs reacted to any regressive ideas. Although this does not represent the views of the population, these channels have large followings and are popular amongst the audience. They can provide useful insights that can create a foundation for future research.

3.3.3 Research Methods and Analysis

This study used TDA for its analysis, a method adopted from Acosta (2020) and Taylor and Ussher (2001). They conduct the analysis by first carrying out a TA, and then conducting a discourse analysis on the selected themes. Rather than just scanning for themes, this method

provides for a more in-depth and insightful analysis of the themes and the language used to create them. Just identifying themes alone is insufficient in the context of this study. To understand the influence of these themes on institutions, it is important to explore how they are created.

The episodes, available on youtube, are transcribed by the author. To ensure the accuracy of the data, the transcribed script is reviewed thrice, twice by the author, and once by an Urdu-speaking colleague. Once the TDA is conducted, the drama is reviewed for a third time, to observe the themes visually. To increase the reliability of the results, the colleague was also asked to conduct a second TDA, which was then correlated with the author's results.

For the TA, the author uses Kiger and Varpio (2020)'s six-step method using Nvivo, with feminist literature as the critical viewpoint for analysis. The six steps of TA are familiarizing yourself with the data, generating initial codes, searching for themes, reviewing the themes, defining and naming the themes and producing the report. These steps allow for thorough combing and collating of the data and descriptive and coherent reporting. A code is defined as “[t]he most basic segment, or element, of the raw data or information that can be assessed in a meaningful way regarding the phenomenon” (Boyatzis, cited in Kiger and Varpio, 2020). Once the themes are established, a Discourse analysis was conducted to examine how language was used to construct the themes, and the influence this would have in constructing reality. The significance of language/discourse is established in Chapter 2 using poststructuralism.

Once the TDA is conducted, the reviews written on the chosen drama by the four blogs will be collected. CDA will be conducted on this text, to analyse how the blogs reacted to the themes derived in the first step. Hodges, Kuper and Reeves (2008) define CDA as

The examination of the text and the social uses of language [and] the study of the ways in which the very existence of specific institutions and of roles for individuals to play are made possible by ways of thinking and speaking.

The text will be coded keeping in mind the themes deduced previously, and the language used to describe or react to those themes will be analysed. The main idea here is to first explore if these themes are being identified by the audience and then if there is a positive or negative attitude towards the themes.

3.4 LIMITATIONS AND CONCLUSION

To conclude, this chapter outlined the research aim, questions, and methods of this paper. The three research questions addressing media and gender in Pakistan are studied using TDA. Although the chosen methodology is the best way to achieve the objectives of the author's research, the design of the research has some limitations.

Firstly, a larger sample of the audience cannot be collected for the second part of the analysis due to ethical restrictions, time constraints and lack of resources. However, analysis related to audience reactions has not been done before in Pakistan, therefore, this paper brings an important addition to the literature. If the author finds that the second part of the analysis provides profound insight, this can create the potential for crucial future research. Secondly, the author cannot analyse more than one drama. However, conducting an in-depth analysis of the entire drama, which is not done in many previous papers, is a strength. A drama is usually released 1 episode a week, which means the character develops and creates an impact over time. A storyline that is built over 30 weeks can be more subtle in how it influences a thought process but can create a long-lasting impression. Therefore, analysis of the entire narrative is more representative of what is being produced rather than a few dialogues, scenes or characters. Finally, despite several advantages of the method, TDA poses some limitations. The nature of

the analysis allows for subjectivity in the interpretations, however, the nuanced and complex analysis needed for this research makes it an appropriate method. To combat the subjectivity, the author's colleague who reviewed the transcripts was also asked to conduct a TA, which was then compared to the analysis conducted by the author. Both analyses found similar themes to be present and increased the reliability of the author's results.

CHAPTER 4: RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

4.1 INTRODUCTION

The trailers and promotional videos of Raqs-e-bismil characterized the central themes of the drama to be love and passion. It was sold as a love story between Moosa and Zohra, however, the TDA revealed many regressive themes to be present in the drama. To be specific, 6 core themes were found, namely Patriarchy, Lack of autonomy of women, Objectification of women, Stereotypical gender traits, Gender Roles, and women's lack of individuality. Each of these themes have subthemes and multiple illustrations of them throughout the drama. The results section of this chapter will elaborate on each theme, identifying its facets, how it is present in the drama, and the discourse that is used to build them. The subsequent section will outline the results of the second part of the analysis; the review channel. This analysis revealed some key insights, finding the audience to be accepting of the regressive themes present in the drama. Finally, Section 4.4 will discuss the linkages between the themes, and how they interact to build up one narrative, as well as how this links back to the literature.

4.2 RESULTS OF THE TDA

For explanations of the themes presented in this section to make sense, it is imperative to first provide some context to the plot of the drama. The story follows the love story of Moosa and Zohra. The series starts with Sakina (Moosa's cousin), who is trying to elope with Kamran. Moosa stops Sakina before she can elope and since the family does not accept Kamran, they forcefully get her married to Essa (Moosa's brother). Qudratullah (Moosa's father), is the patriarch of the family, with Moosa as his successor. Moosa's father does not accept Zohra and instead gets Moosa engaged to Sitara. However, Moosa refuses to marry Sitara and is disowned by his father. He moves in with his friend Murad and starts working for Laila, a movie producer.

Meanwhile, Zohra is married off to Malik, who is already married and has kids. When his family discovers his second marriage, he divorces Zohra and evicts her out of his house. A series of events bring Zohra to the blue shrine, where Qudratullah and his sons work. Qudratullah decides to give her refuge because she seems to have no family. Eventually, Qudratullah sees what a pious girl Zohra really is, and once he finds out Zohra's identity, he gets Zohra and Moosa married and accepts Moosa back into the family.

4.2.1 Patriarchy

Not surprisingly, patriarchy came through as a prominent theme throughout the series. The theme is an overarching one, with the others either building on to this or emerging from this theme. While TA of the script brought forth explicit portrayals of patriarchal ideology, a deeper dive using DA also revealed many implicit ways that were used to fortify the patriarchal theme. The theme seems to be skillfully woven into the story through the dialogues, how the scenes were framed, the body language of the characters, and the storyline. The nuanced portrayal of the theme, while subtle, is extremely impactful in depicting patriarchy in a positive light.

The framing of the scene and placement of characters add an element of visual discourse that significantly help add to the overall theme. As seen in Figure 1 below, the men are placed at the front of the scene with the women usually standing behind. This placement portrays women as inferior and less important than men.



Figure 1: Women Placed behind Men (Source: Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

If the women are not standing behind the men, they are usually sitting while the men stand (see **Figure 2**). Again, this is a way to make women look smaller and inferior to men.



Figure 2: Men placed above women (Source: Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

In the scenes that do position the men and women equally, the patriarch is strategically placed in the middle of the scene or the middle of the other characters with everyone pointed towards him (see **Figure 3**). Placing the patriarch at the centre of the frame is a way to make him seem important, as the eyeline goes directly to the person at the centre first. The strategic placement of these scenes emphasizes the power of the men in the household and intensifies the lower status of the women.



Figure 3: Patriarch placed in the centre (Source: Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

There are only two instances where Qudratullah is seen in an equal position to someone else in the scene (see Figure 4). Both were when he was talking to Sitara's father, who is the patriarch of his own house and therefore is not inferior to Qudratullah. The framing of the scene might seem like a small detail, but visual cues go a long way in depicting certain themes and building a narrative to strengthen the intended impact on the viewer (Bandtel and Tenscher, 2014; Benattabou, 2020; Wang, 2014).



Figure 4: Two Patriarchs in one scene (Pic on the Left from Episode 7, Pic on the right from Episode 12) (Source: Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

Additionally, the more obvious instances of patriarchy can be seen in the decision-making power the husbands in the series have relative to their wives. An example of this is the storyline between Malik Shahryar and Zohra. Throughout their relationship, you see Malik Shahryar order Zohra around, and Zohra complies with his orders despite voicing that it goes against her wishes. He controls what she wears, where she goes and who she meets. He refuses to let Zohra meet her family. Zohra's mother agrees to this and forbids Zohra from coming home because she needs to "honour her husband's wishes" (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Her obedience to him is time and again tagged as her "being a good wife" and her "duty" (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Malik at one point even says: "As long as we are married, you have no choice but to do as I say" (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). The language and narrative used to justify Zohra's actions create the impression that she is right in her behaviour.

The male dominance that patriarchy engenders can also be seen through Malik and his first wife's storyline. When the first wife's family find out he got married to Zohra, her brothers come and confront Malik. The brothers initially approach Malik to pressure him into divorcing Zohra but eventually decide that he will divorce their sister without ever consulting her. Moreover, the wife seems to own a lot of property in the village, which is all given to Malik to control. Throughout the series, we do not see Malik's first wife or even hear her name. Any decisions that we see being made for her, like her property being sold, her divorce, or her relocation to the city, it is all decided by either Malik or her brothers.

Similarly, the power imbalance between genders is present in the house of Quadratullah as well. The women are rarely seen making decisions, rather they follow whatever directions their husbands give them. Sakina's mother Khadijah (a widow) follows her brother Quadratullah's orders. Her character is used to build the idea that women who are alone are helpless and that

they need a patriarch in their lives to survive. This idea is reiterated using the following dialogues said by Khadijah:

“If my husband was alive things would have been different, but I am answerable to my brother without him”

“I am powerless and dependent on my brother’s scraps. Had your father been alive today he would have fought for you, but your widowed mother cannot do anything but obey”

“I only have the support of my brother and his roof; I cannot go against him”
(Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

This narrative that men need to make decisions for women is also seen through the storyline of Zohra ending up at the house of Qudratullah. When Zohra faints at the blue shrine and Qudratullah finds her, he immediately takes her to his house. He declares her as his daughter when he finds out that she does not have a father and is divorced. This entire storyline is extremely problematic and perfectly depicts patriarchal ideology. Qudratullah could have given Zohra shelter for the sake of humanity, but felt the need to say, “she is my daughter from today” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021), depicting the idea that a single woman needs a male figure in her life. Qudratullah on many occasions says, “she is my responsibility now” when Zohra claims she does not have any male relatives (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021).

After a few months of Zohra staying at Qudratullah’s house, he decides he will get Zohra married. He claims that as the only male figure in her life, it is up to him to make this decision for her. Zohra, who is still in love with Moosa, claims that she will do whatever Qudratullah “commands [her] to do” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). The word command and obedience are used multiple times in this narrative, reiterating the power imbalance between men and women. Despite many people trying to convince her to tell Qudratullah that she loves Moosa, she refuses to disobey him and is then called “honourable”, “respectful” and “righteous” for doing so (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). The fact that Zohra is blindly obeying Qudratullah and forgoing her wishes is glorified throughout the episodes. Many characters are seen praising her for her

obedience. This glorification is a subtle way to depict patriarchy in a positive light and highlight the superior status of men. Ultimately, a series of events lead to the marriage of Zohra and Moosa; however, it only happens because Qudratullah agrees. The happy end is not a result of Zohra's love for Moosa, but rather Qudratullah's willingness to allow it to happen.

4.2.2 Lack of autonomy for women

The series begins with Sakina's attempt to elope with Kamran, establishing the idea that the women of the Qudratullah family have no autonomy over their lives. Moosa finds Sakina before she can elope, and forcefully brings her back home. Qudratullah then decides that Essa and Sakina are going to get married, a decision made without acquiring her consent. After the marriage, Sakina time and again reminds Essa and Khadijah that she is not happy, that she feels "trapped" and "suffocated", but she is forced to stay because they must honour Qudratullah's decision (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Despite knowing Sakina's true feelings, her mother (Khadijah) does nothing to support her; rather, constantly berates Sakina for being upset about the marriage. She uses sentences like "is this how I raised you", or "do not embarrass me by going against brother's orders" to blackmail Sakina into accepting the marriage (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Khadijah also constantly reminds Sakina after the marriage that she has a duty towards her husband and has no choice but to be "a good, dutiful wife to him" (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021).

There are many ways to reiterate or strengthen an idea, one of them is the progression of a storyline. Kamran is eventually portrayed as a negative character, establishing the idea that Qudratullah as the patriarch knew better than Sakina. Sakina admits that she did not know better and eventually says that she is "glad [she] was forced to marry Essa" (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). The way this storyline concluded and the language that was used to construct it conveys

the idea that women did not need autonomy because men were the better decision makers. This also adds to the theme of Patriarchy.

Furthermore, another illustration of the lack of autonomy found in this drama is the restricted mobility faced by women. The women do not go anywhere without permission, and they leave only with men as their “protectors” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Khadijah is never seen outside of the house throughout the series. Hajra (Moosa’s mother) only leaves the house once, and that too after asking her husband for permission. In addition, she takes her younger son with her because she is not allowed to leave alone. Sakina is also seen asking for permission to leave the house multiple times from her father-in-law and her husband. One of those times her father-in-law also goes on to say:

Abba: “It is not appropriate for women to leave the house to meet friends, better leave your college friends behind now.” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

In the first episode when Moosa brings Sakina back home one of the first things he says is ‘who did she ask before leaving’ (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Establishing the idea that the women of this household have no autonomy. At one point, when Essa refuses to let Sakina go to her friend’s house, she calls this out by saying “why do you want to trap me in this house?”, to which her husband responds “okay, you can go, but you need to bring the driver with you” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Sakina’s mother later comments on this by saying:

Khadija: “Essa should not have given permission to Sakina. Brother will not be happy about this, and if Essa wasn’t present, she could have gone with Moosa.” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

There are several dialogues like these throughout the series that reiterate the idea that men not only impose their decisions on women, but women also accept their decision-making role as if it’s the only way to function. The same trend is seen in Sitara’s household. She sneaks out multiple times because she does not get permission to go meet her fiancé. Moreover, her mother

is only seen outside of the household with her husband. All the above storylines clearly portray the fact that women of the family are very restricted in where they go, they need the patriarch's permission if they want to go anywhere and if they go out, they need to be escorted by a male figure. What strengthens this idea is the language that is used to describe these women. They are constantly referred to as "righteous", "honourable", and "pious" women (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). They are glorified for the way they live, indirectly reiterating the idea that the restriction of mobility is appropriate. The only woman in this series who has autonomy over her life is Laila, the movie producer. However, she is constantly called a dishonourable woman and claims to be unhappy with the way her life is. Her character is a subtle way to reinforce the superiority of men and the need to have them control women.

4.2.3 Objectification of women

There are many ways that a woman can be objectified; this series uses beauty as the objectifying factor. Zohra and Sakina, the central female protagonists, are educated at good universities. However, this fact is mentioned in passing once or twice and has not received much attention. Rather, the focus of both the girls' personalities is their beauty, especially Zohra's. Moosa falls in love with Zohra at first sight. Figure 5 shows the scene where Moosa apparently falls in love with Zohra. He doesn't talk to her and can only see her eyes.



Figure 5: Zohra and Moosa's first meeting (Source: Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

He instantly becomes obsessed with her and begins to stalk her. He proposes to her many times despite her rejecting him on many occasions. Using love as an excuse he continues to follow her, despite knowing nothing about her and only having seen her “beautiful eyes” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Throughout the series, he learns nothing about her, her personality, or her intellect. Regardless, his obsessiveness is encouraged by the rest who call him, “passionate”, “a man of the heart”, “a real man”, “a heart of gold” and “a true treasure” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). His treatment of Zohra is constantly glorified throughout the script by many characters, including Anna Ji, Chanda, Khadijah, Sakina, Murad, Hajra, Essa, and Saranga. Eventually, despite being treated as the object in this scenario, even Zohra glorifies all his actions by calling him a “true lover” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). When Sitara finds out that he is in love with Zohra, her first reaction is the following:

Sitara: “is she really pretty? Look at my craziness is that even a question to ask? I'm sure she is absolutely beautiful, the most beautiful and ravishing that is why she has captured your heart.” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

The insinuation in this dialogue is that the sole reason he could have fallen in love with her is her beauty. Nobody mentions her intellect or personality; rather, her entire character arc resolves around her beauty. Moreover, this theme can also be illustrated through the reactions of the other characters when they first meet her or when they talk about her further emphasizing her beauty.

Hajra: “you have captured him with the shackles of your beauty. He has not been able to come out of the first sight of you”

Sakina: “I don't know any of that, but she is very beautiful. I don't understand how someone can divorce a pure and beautiful woman like her.”

Sitara: “I went to meet your Zohra, but then I forgot everything because I got lost just looking at her beauty.”

Hajra: “Moosa was right, your beauty can make anyone forget his memory.”

Malik: “No, no, obviously, such a beautiful girl requires such a protocol.”

Shahzab gill: “I will meet you again Zohra, Malik is quite the cheetah; he always preys on the prettiest ones of the market.”

Shehryar: “you are a beautiful woman; I am sure you will find many options out there.”
(Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

4.2.4 Stereotypical Personality Traits of genders

Another theme consistent throughout the series is the stereotypical personality traits that genders seem to have. Any character that doesn't conform to the stereotypes is treated as a deviant or outcast. Men are portrayed as aggressive and violent; rather, they are also applauded for it. Moosa and Essa are both shown holding guns on many occasions (**see Figure 6**). In one of the pictures in Figure 6, Moosa brings out a gun just because two men were refusing to come to an agreement with Laila about a business deal. His aggression is rewarded

throughout the drama. He is portrayed as “honourable” and a man of “integrity” for being able to protect his family through violence and aggression (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Both Tauqeer (Laila’s husband) and Malik are also shown as aggressive characters. On many occasions, they are found talking in a very stern tone even in normal conversations. Qudratullah also has a constant harsh tone and aggressive body language in all his scenes.



Figure 6: Aggression/Violence in Men (Source: Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

On the other end, Kamran is portrayed in a negative light for being the opposite. Moosa threatened him and his family, so he decided to give up instead of resorting to violence or risking his family’s life. Sakina and Essa on multiple occasions call him a “coward”, “spineless”, and “not a real man” because he refused to resort to violence (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Eventually, Sakina claims “she fell out of love” because he refused to “protect” her like a “real man” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Toxic masculinity seems to be highly rewarded in the series. Even men who show aggression for no reason or in an inappropriate manner are claimed to be behaving like they are meant to.

Women, on the other hand, are shown to be docile, nurturing, and emotional. Figure 7 shows the contrast between the men and women in the series. In all these screenshots the characters are upset or angry about something. The men almost always react by screaming and threatening. Their facial expressions alone clearly depict their anger. In contrast, the female characters are more sober in their reactions to these situations. Even their facial expressions as seen in the figure are much softer than those of the men. They usually react in a very calm manner and barely raise their voice. Moreover, even in anger, they mostly resort to crying rather than displaying aggression towards someone else (see **figure 8**). Both Khadijah and Hajra are constantly seen as calm nurturing figures, taking care of their children. Their children are seen going to them, sharing their feelings with them, and being cared for by them. On the other hand, Qudratullah seems to be a very distant father, he is mostly seen as a decision maker. His interaction with his sons mostly addresses work-related topics rather than personal topics.



Figure 7: Aggression in Men vs Women (Source: Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)



Figure 8: Depiction of Emotional Women (Source: Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

Sakina's entire character arc builds on the stereotypical portrayal of traits. Initially, Sakina is portrayed as a negative character. She is shown as an outspoken, determined, and decisive person, who stands up for herself and is a bit aggressive in her mannerisms. She seems to be a female version of Moosa; however, she is condemned for being so. Quadratullah on multiple occasions says he made a mistake letting her get educated because she has become "too independent" and is "on a path of shame and disgrace" (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Moosa on the other hand is constantly praised for the way he is, although both were doing the same thing, voicing their opinions, and making their own decisions. After a series of events, Sakina goes through an enlightenment and her character suddenly changes. She becomes docile, her tone changes, she starts obeying her father-in-law and husband, and she stops voicing her own opinions. Rather she is seen blindly supporting whatever her husband says and does. After this change, many praise her. Her mother even says she used to be "Satan", but she has now

“changed for the better by letting go of her stubbornness” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Her husband says he is very proud of her for changing her ways and loves her even more now. Her change in demeanour can be seen in Figure 9. The pictures on the left show her before her big change and the ones on the right show her after. The softness in her expressions, her submissive and calm demeanour, is evident on the right side, and the opposite is evident on the left. The discourse used to build this storyline strengthens the idea that people need to conform to gender-specific personality traits.

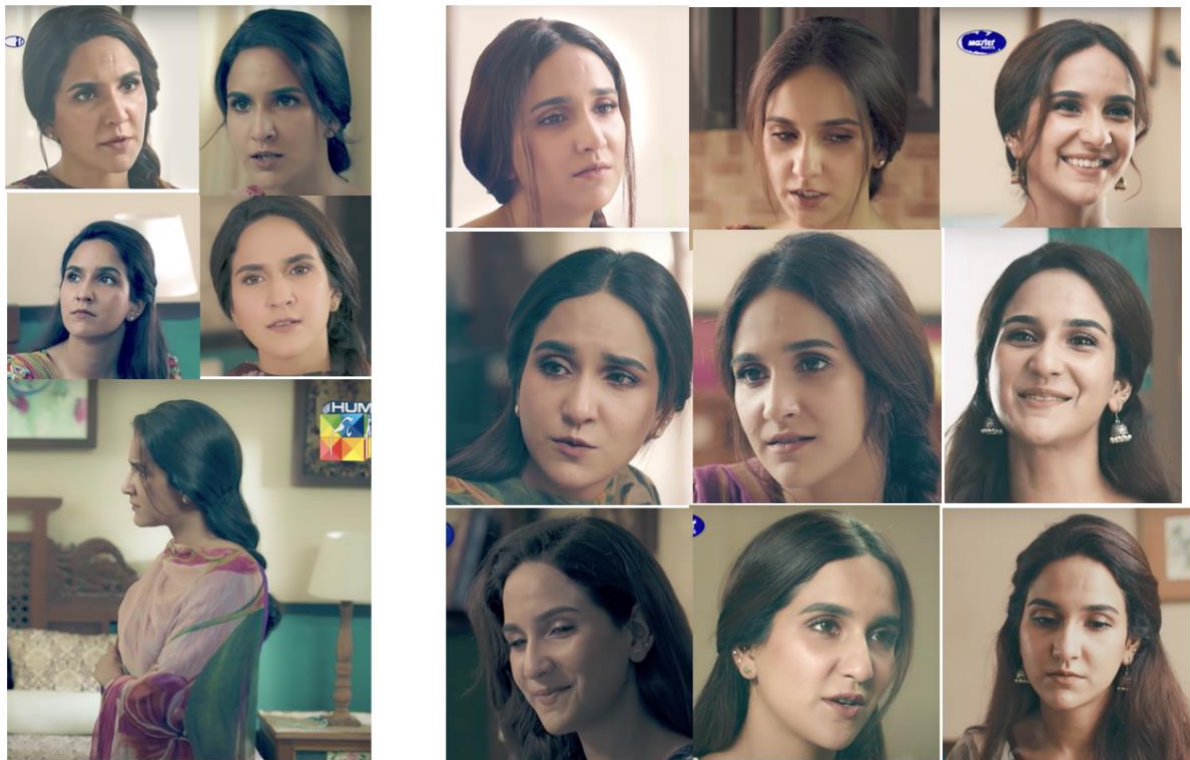


Figure 9: Sakina's shift in character (Source: Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

Additionally, men are shown to be assertive and self-sufficient, whereas women are shown to be submissive and dependent on men. This can be seen in the relationships between the husbands and wives: Qudratullah and Hajrah, Essa and Sakina, Zohra and Shehryar. As

mentioned in section 4.2.1, men are seen imposing their opinions on women, whereas women are seen as submitting and following with no opinions of their own. Hajra at one-point claims:

Hajra: “Remember that if I have to choose between my son and my husband, then I will bow in front of my husband without a second thought.” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

When Zohra rejects Moosa, he kidnaps her to try to get married to her. He eventually lets her go after she breaks down but does not stop trying to win her over. This action of his is later deemed an “act of true love” by everyone (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). This storyline perfectly depicts the assertive nature of men. In addition to the relationship dynamics, their body language is consistently seen to be in a submissive state when they are talking to their men. They either talk with their heads hung down or look at the floor while speaking (see figure 10). Their subservient nature is perfectly illustrated by the figure below.



Figure 10: Submissive Stance of Women (Source: Raqs-e-bismil)

In addition, women are seen to be dependent on men, unable to make any decisions without their assistance and needing their constant protection. Evidence of this is also discussed in section 4.2.2. Khadijah even claims several times that she is “helpless” because her husband isn’t alive to protect and support her (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Even Sakina and Moosa’s relationship is shown as one where Moosa since her childhood has been her saviour and protector as her brother.

With Laila being the breadwinner of the family, one would expect to see a different dynamic between the two. Instead, not much is different in their situation. Tauqeer is seen as assertive and controlling, and Laila in many situations is seen as having to agree with him. After a series of events led to Tauqeer being arrested and charged for attempted murder, Laila claims that she now has no purpose. She even goes on to say that she wishes she had found someone like Moosa, who could take care of her and protect her. Despite being a successful actress and producer, she is shown to need a man to survive and be happy.

4.2.5 Gender Roles

Another very prominent theme in the drama is the portrayal of gender-specific roles. Men are seen in productive roles outside the household, whereas women are seen in caretaking and reproductive roles within the household. The idea that a woman’s sole duty is to her husband and her children is constantly reinforced throughout the drama. Firstly, Qudratullah and his sons are seen handling all the responsibilities of the blue shrine, while the women sit at home. It is revealed at the beginning that Sakina holds a graduate degree from a well-ranked University, while Essa does not. Regardless, she does not attempt to perform any productive roles outside of the house; rather she seems satisfied staying at home “serving her husband” while her less-educated husband is the breadwinner (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). There are many

instances where language is used to illustrate the theme of gender roles; some of them are mentioned below.

Khadija: “A wife should know where her husband is, how could you let him go without serving him any breakfast.”

Hajra: “I will find you a good obedient wife, who will serve you and take care of you.”

Moosa: “Are you going to be tied to our mother’s apron strings all day or what? We have a thousand things that need doing so come outside.”

Shah jee: “the women at home got left with all the many foods they’d prepared for your arrival.”

Sakina: “Let me find your watch for you. Anyway, I am the one who keeps track of where all your things are.”

Qudratullah: “well, I will find you a good and pious wife who will serve you well.”

Anna Ji: “anyway, you are not going to work in an office after studying so much, better to accept the proposal and settle down.”

Zohra: “I wish I could take care of you, cook something delicious for you.

Moosa: All I want Zohra, is to be with you for the rest of my life. I will give you charge of my kitchen, and you can raise our beautiful children.”

Essa: “She deserves someone better than me; she is so educated and beautiful.

Hajra: You are a prince Essa, you can protect her and honour her, that is all she will ever need.” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

Zohra also holds a master’s degree, but it seems that she can only work as a dancer, which she is consistently shamed for. The fact that Zohra, Sakina, and even Sitara have a degree is mentioned in the passing, and none of them seem to even want to take on a productive role. Malik tries to encourage Zohra to help him with his business deal after they get married, but she constantly says that she wants to be a “normal wife who runs her household well” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Laila is the one character who is employed, but she seems to be dissatisfied with this life. She even says:

Laila: “If it was up to me, I would sit at home and let my husband work. It is far from easy for a woman to be out in this world alone.” (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

The one employed woman repeatedly claims she is not happy with the way her life is.

This entire narrative is a subtle way to reinforce the idea that women belong in the household.

4.2.6 Lack of Individuality of women

Not only are women subjected to a rigid gender role, but it also seems their identity and entire being is purely attached to being married and being a wife. It is rare to find a female character that has an identity of their own. Ultimately, they are all wives before anything else. This idea is developed in several ways. Firstly, it is constantly mentioned that a wife is the husband's honour. What is meant by this is that the wife belongs to the husband, and therefore the way a person would protect their own honour, their wife needs to be protected and treated in a similar manner. Honour is mentioned a total of 44 times in the entire series, 32 of those are talking about Women being the honour of their father or their husband. Out of all of the scenes between Zohra and Malik, 2/3 of them are Zohra telling Malik that she is his honour. This idea that a woman belongs to the man is also reinforced by the following dialogues:

Sakina's friend: "when a lover becomes someone else's wife it doesn't take long for his love to die."

Hajra: "a girl does eventually fall in love with her husband and any feelings of love that one ever felt prior to it become unimportant." (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

Secondly, there are two divorced women (Zohra and Laila), one widow (Khadijah) and one with a broken engagement (Sitara). Zohra and Laila are treated as if their lives are over after the divorce. Laila claims she no longer has a purpose in her life and Zohra time and again says she wants to die because she has no reason to live. She even says that her life has been destroyed because of the divorce. Moreover, after her divorce, Zohra says she cannot go back home because her mother told her never to return after she got married. Despite growing up with her mother, she cannot return to her just because her identity now belongs to her husband.

Khadijah, who is a widow, is on multiple occasions heard stating she is just a helpless woman who is trying to live out the rest of her days with the support of her brother. There is also a narrative that once her husband divorces her, a woman doesn't need to be adorned.

Zohra: "I don't want anything. A divorcee only needs a white shawl."

Khadija: "A widow or a divorcee do not need such fancy clothes. Anything simple and black or white will do. Once she loses a husband, a woman dies on the inside." (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021)

These dialogues reinforce the idea that without a man attached to her, a woman does not have an identity. Sitara has her engagement broken off twice in the drama, after that she is admitted to a hospital because she is depressed. Again, Sitara is shown as a competent and intelligent girl. However, her entire storyline surrounds trying to get married, and when she doesn't, she gets too depressed to even function properly.

Finally, the previously mentioned storyline where Qudratullah claims Zohra is his daughter now also adds to this narrative. The implication is that without the name of a man attached to her, she is alone and helpless and therefore Qudratullah feels the need to take her on as his daughter. He could have just given her a place for refuge for a few days, but the narrative that she is now his responsibility is constantly brought up.

4.3 DISCOURSE ANALYSIS OF REVIEW CHANNELS

The analysis presented in the previous section outlines not only themes that were present in the drama, but also how the themes were built up to impact the viewer. The analysis of the review channel conducted in this section provides useful insights into the impact these themes are making on the viewer. Due to a lack of resources, a large sample of viewer reactions cannot be collected, therefore the review channels are used as a proxy for the audience. While

these findings cannot be generalized to the larger audience, the analysis provides a good starting point and foundation for future research in this area.

Overall, none of the review channels seemed to address the blatant patriarchy that was present in the drama. Rather, there seemed to be appreciation for the way Qudratullah's family was portrayed. Moreover, all four of the review channels on multiple occasions celebrated the power that Qudratullah's character exuded and seemed to be in awe of how he was interacting with his family. Moreover, the aggression of the male characters is appreciated as well. Moosa's character is praised for being a "hero" and "passionate lover" (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). While the question of Moosa's assertiveness did raise some alarms for 2 of the review channels, they eventually just called it an "act of true love" (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Essa's aggressive scenes with his wife are also applauded with comments like "it was interesting to see Essa's aggressive side come out" and "Essa's manliness has finally come out and it was refreshing to see" (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021).

Sakina's character is also questioned until her big change. She is called 'bitter', 'venomous' and 'vindictive', even in the episodes where all she did was stand up for herself. Once she begins to conform to stereotypical personality traits, she begins to get more praise and acceptance from the reviewers. The reviewers did mention that Moosa did not do right by Sakina by not letting her elope, however as the series went on there seemed to be an acceptance that it turned out to be right for her. The fact that Sakina lost her autonomy in that situation was quickly forgotten. On the other hand, it was interesting to see the hate that Kamran received. He decided to back off to save his family, however, he was insulted by the reviewers on multiple occasions for not having the guts that a man should have. Moreover, there seems to be no mention in the reviews of the gender roles that are present in the drama. It can only be

assumed that gender roles are recognized by the audience as the natural way of life and therefore did not invite any comments. This also seems to be true for the blatant portrayal of patriarchy that exists.

4.4 DISCUSSION

The results of the TDA revealed many intriguing insights that provide elaborate answers to the research questions of this paper. The first research question (how men and women appear in popular Pakistani dramas) was answered in section 4.2. To round up the answer to this question it is useful to discuss the linkages between the themes. When looked at from a singular lens, all the themes interlink to create a single narrative: the inferiority of womenkind and the devaluation of femininity. While each standalone theme speaks to this narrative, as the themes begin to fit together like puzzle pieces, their impact on the audience magnifies.

The themes of lack of autonomy of women and the women's lack of individuality go together with the theme of Patriarchy. The man, as the powerholder has the higher status and therefore has control over his household members, more specifically, his wife. As the inferior individual in every scenario, the women's identity then revolves around the men. These themes emerge from patriarchal ideology and act to strengthen the system. Additionally, the objectification of women also further adds to the inferior characterization of women. The disregard for their intellect and personality and focus on just their beauty implies they have nothing of substance to contribute as economic agents. This is further illustrated by the gender roles that emerge from patriarchal values; as the breadwinners' men automatically gain more bargaining power and claim their position as heads of the households. The theme of stereotypical personality traits elicits similar interpretations. The depiction of men as decisive, assertive, competent, and aggressive emerges from the ideology that they are superior. Whereas the nurturing, docile, and submissive nature of women is depicted as weak and inferior to those of men, with men

needing to protect women. What strengthens all these ideas is that these themes are in many ways glorified through the series. Most of the female characters are shown pushing the narrative that they cannot exist without the protection of men. They accept their inferior position in society and are called “honourable”, “respectable” and “pious” women for doing so (Raqs-e-bismil, 2021). Many instances of this can be found in the scenes and dialogues outlined in section 4.2.

The second research question (to what extent does the identity of men and women presented on Pakistani television coincide with the socio-cultural institutions of the country) can be answered by exploring the linkages between the results and the literature review. The narrative previously discussed seems to perfectly align with the literature outlined in this paper. Section 2.3.1 of Chapter 2 identifies patriarchy as Pakistan's principal informal social system, with three central social norms that intensify the social exclusion of women. The three norms are: rigid gender roles, stereotypical personality traits and power imbalance between men and women. The themes found perfectly coincide with the socio-cultural institutions of Pakistan discussed in chapter two. The rigid gender roles and patriarchal values present in society clearly translate on the screen. In addition to that, the women that are seen attempting to take on productive roles are either portrayed as dishonourable or unfulfilled and depressed characters. This can be interpreted as a way of discouraging any deviation from patriarchal values and assigned gender roles. The stereotypical personality traits and power imbalance are also evident throughout the series. There was no instance of a female character making a decision for herself in the series; if at any point she did make a personal decision, it was either condemned or required the approval of a male figure. Moreover, as previously discussed in section 4.2.4, not only does every single character in the series depict stereotypical personality traits, but any divergence from them is either eventually corrected or condemned and negatively received.

The final question (How do popular review channels react to how gender is presented in TV dramas) has already been answered in section 4.3, however, to achieve the aim of this paper, it's important to discuss the implication of these findings. Beyond examining the representation of Pakistani society on screen, it is also necessary to explore how these representations affect society. One facet of this is the findings outlined in Section 4.3. A major insight from this section is that the themes depicted are positively received and applauded by the audience. In some instances, the themes are not even being acknowledged; the assumption for which is that because these themes are being perceived as normal and unproblematic, they are not even being addressed. A trend found in the reviews was that anything that did not sit well with the reviewers was addressed and talked about. If a topic is not discussed, it can be safely assumed that it is not out of the ordinary or flawed for the viewer and therefore is not even acknowledged.

As described in section 4.2, the discourse used to create the themes validates them in two ways, either glorifying them or discouraging any deviations from them. This can condition people into accepting certain beliefs and rejecting others, inevitably, as post-structuralism suggests, shaping the value system of society. The themes present in this drama were also found in other Pakistani research outlined in section 2.4. The ultimate consequence of the constant portrayal of these themes is the reinforcement of the inferiority of women, which continues to exacerbate gender inequalities.

4.5 CONCLUSION

The themes that emerged from the data, their significance, and their impact on the socio-cultural institutions of Pakistan have been discussed at length in this chapter. It is clear the

extensive role discourse has played in the portrayal of men and women on television and the impact this has on gender identity in Pakistan. The inferiority of women and the devaluation of femininity encouraged by the media can impact the social realities Pakistani women have to face. Their lack of economic, political, and social rights can all be linked back to the societal values that endorse their inferiority. The ideas proposed and evidenced in this section have policy implications for Pakistan that are further discussed in chapter 5.

CHAPTER 5: CONCLUSION

This article has endeavoured to establish a link between media, gender inequality and social institutions in Pakistan. Post-structural feminism suggests that discourse used to depict gender in media can shape social realities and gender identity. Therefore, the author has used TDA to analyse the most popular TV Drama of 2021, *Raqs-e-bismil*, to gain insight into how gender is presented on television. The results of the TDA are evaluated against the literature to establish the extent to which gender identity and norms presented on television coincide with the sociocultural institutions of the country. The author also conducted a discourse analysis on Pakistani review channels, which are used as a proxy for the audience, to gain insight into how the audience reacts to the themes present in the drama. All the different levels of analyses are combined to understand the possible impact media can have on gender inequality in Pakistan. This chapter summarises the key findings, future research implications as well as policy implications of this paper.

5.1 SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

The TDA revealed 6 central themes, namely, Patriarchy, Lack of Autonomy for Women, Objectification of Women, Stereotypical Personality Traits and Lack of Individuality of Women. Each of these themes depicted the inferiority of women and the devaluation of femininity. The narrative that these themes created represented the socio-cultural institutions of Pakistan. On the other end, the analysis of the review channels revealed a positive attitude towards the themes presented. Taken together, these findings suggest that broadcast media in Pakistan portrays regressive gender attitudes that can shape, reinforce, and sustain the current informal social institutions of the country. The ever-increasing gender inequality that deprives women of their entitlements, rights and resources can be attributed to the informal social

institutions operating in Pakistan. This study provides the foundation for future research that can further increase our understanding of the subject as well as justify better policies.

5.2 RESEARCH IMPLICATIONS

The research implications of this paper are vast, encompassing many possible areas of investigation. Firstly, the results of this paper merit further research into other forms of media, such as news, advertisements, films, and social media. If television has an impact on the institutions of Pakistan, other forms of media could also reveal profound insights. The analysis of the review channels also creates a foundation for further extensive research. Due to a lack of resources, the audience could not be investigated for this paper, therefore, the review channels were used as a proxy. The preliminary results do bring forth interesting insights. Larger-scale research into the audience's reactions to gender portrayal in media (research that has not yet been done in Pakistan) can bring further insights into the exact role of media and the mechanisms that shape social realities in the country. Finally, the link between gender inequality, social institutions and media established in this paper also merits research into relevant policies that might reduce gender inequality.

5.3 POLICY IMPLICATIONS

While there are many ways to tackle gender inequality, the most logical way is to dismantle the root of the problem and fix that first. If socio-cultural institutions contribute to gender inequality, then an appropriate intervention is to create a shift in the attitudes created by them. Furthermore, if broadcast media plays a role in shaping these socio-cultural institutions, then regulation of broadcast media could be a useful intervention. Pakistan Electronic Media Regulatory Authority (PEMRA) is a federal institution in Pakistan that regulates all media outlets in the country. The authority control what can and cannot be displayed on TV. For example, it prohibits intimate scenes, blood, and weapons to be shown

on TV and has the authority to block any film or television drama that does not comply with its regulation from airing. One possible policy intervention could be the prohibition of the portrayal of domestic violence on television. Just looking at Raqs-e-bismil, there are multiple scenes where husbands are shown being violent towards their wives, however, at no point are they condemned for their actions. The normalisation and glorification of domestic violence that is easily depicted in not just Raqs-e-bismil, but many television dramas can be controlled by PEMRA. This alone could decrease the gendered power imbalance portrayed on television. Moreover, PEMRA could deploy a program to incentivize scripts that depict strong empowering female leads. These are long-term interventions that could eventually change the status of women in Pakistan.

The impact of policies that regulate social institutions can be profound in many ways. Ultimately, the issue is the inferiority of women that is embedded in the value system of the country. This creates an underestimation of women and creates barriers for them in many ways. If most employers are men who believe in the inferiority of women, it can be hard for women to gain employment until these values change. If the policymakers, who are also mostly men, believe in the inferiority of women, then they are likely to create insensitive and gender-blind policies that worsen the condition of women. If women do find a political voice, they are much less likely to listen to them or distribute the power and resources they need to survive. The impact of a change in these attitudes runs deep and could be the key to changing the course of gender inequality in the country.

To the author, the results of this study have highlighted just how deeply rooted patriarchy is in Pakistan. The final takeaway from this paper is that the key to reducing gender inequality is not just empowering women. Rather, as those who still hold much of the political, economic,

and household bargaining power, it is imperative that men are part of the process as both allies and vehicles of change.

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